

CSS Quotes Property

Complete Guide: Easy English Explanation

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 What is the Quotes Property?

The `quotes` property in CSS defines what quotation mark characters to use when generating quotes with the `<q>` HTML element or the `::before` and `::after` pseudo-elements with `content: open-quote` and `content: close-quote`.

Think of quotes like international translations:

- **English:** Uses “straight quotes” or *curly quotes*
- **French:** Uses « guillemets » with spaces
- **German:** Uses »straight quotes« or „curved quotes”
- CSS quotes lets you change what marks appear

The `quotes` property controls which quote characters display for your language and style!

1.2 Why Use the Quotes Property?

The `quotes` property is useful for:

- Proper quotation marks for different languages
- Matching typography styles (formal vs casual)
- Automatic nested quotes (quotes within quotes)
- Consistent quote styling across the entire site
- Accessible quotation mark handling
- Typography control without changing HTML
- Supporting multiple languages
- Professional document styling

1.3 How It Works

1.3.1 Without CSS quotes

```
<q>Hello world</q>  
  
<!-- Browser default (usually looks like: "Hello world" ) -->
```

1.3.2 With CSS quotes

```
q {  
  quotes: "«" "»";  
  /* Now displays: « Hello world » */  
}
```

1.4 Works With

The quotes property affects:

- `<q>` HTML element (inline quotation)
- `::before` and `::after` pseudo-elements using `open-quote` and `close-quote`
- Nested `<q>` elements (different quote levels)
- Not `<blockquote>` (different purpose)

Chapter 2

Understanding Quotes Syntax

2.1 Basic Syntax

```
quotes: "opening" "closing";
/* Single level quotes */

quotes: "opening1" "closing1" "opening2" "closing2";
/* Nested quotes (2 levels) */

quotes: opening1 closing1 opening2 closing2 opening3 closing3;
/* Multiple nesting levels */
```

2.2 Simple Example

```
/* English style (straight quotes) */
q {
  quotes: ' ' ' ';
}

/* English style (curly quotes) */
q {
  quotes: ' ' ' ';
}

/* French style (guillemets) */
q {
  quotes: "«" "»";
}

/* German style */
q {
  quotes: „" " ";
}

/* Spanish style */
q {
  quotes: "«" "»";
}
```

```
}  
  
/* Japanese style */  
q {  
  quotes: " " " " ;  
}
```

Chapter 3

Quote Levels and Nesting

3.1 How Nesting Works

When you have quotes within quotes, CSS automatically changes to the next level:

```
q {
  quotes: ' ' ' '          /* Level 1: outer quotes */
         " " " "          /* Level 2: inner quotes */
}
```

3.1.1 HTML with nested quotes

```
<p>He said, <q>She told me, <q>Hello</q>,
so I replied</q>.</p>
```

3.1.2 Result

```
He said, "She told me, 'Hello', so I replied".
```

Explanation:

- Outer <q>: Uses level 1 quotes (" ")
- Inner <q>: Uses level 2 quotes (' ')
- Automatic switching based on nesting depth

3.2 Multiple Nesting Levels

```
q {
  quotes: ' ' ' '          /* Level 1 */
         " " " "          /* Level 2 */
         '«' '»'          /* Level 3 */
         ' ' > ' ' ;       /* Level 4 */
}
```

When you nest <q> elements:

- First <q> uses level 1 quotes

- `<q>` inside it uses level 2 quotes
- `<q>` inside that uses level 3 quotes
- And so on...

Chapter 4

Common Quote Styles by Language

4.1 English

4.1.1 Straight Quotes (Typewriter Style)

```
q {  
  quotes: ' ' ' ' " " " "  
}
```

Result: “Hello”, then ‘she said’

4.1.2 Curly Quotes (Typography Style)

```
q {  
  quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' '  
}
```

Result: "Hello", then 'she said'

4.2 French

```
q {  
  quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' '  
}
```

Result: « Bonjour », then "she said"

French uses guillemets with spaces inside.

4.3 German

```
q {  
  quotes: „" " " „" " "  
}
```

Result: „Hallo”, then ,she said’

4.4 Spanish

```
q {
  quotes: "«" "»" '‘' '’';
}
```

Result: « Hola », then "she said"

4.5 Japanese

```
q {
  quotes: "" "" "" "";
}
```

Result: , then she said

4.6 Russian

```
q {
  quotes: "«" "»" „" "„";
}
```

Result: « », then „she said”

Chapter 5

Using with CSS Content

5.1 ::before and ::after with open-quote/close-quote

```
q {
  quotes: ' ' ' ' " " " ";
}

q::before {
  content: open-quote;
}

q::after {
  content: close-quote;
}

/* Equivalent to using <q> element */
```

5.2 Complete Example

```
q {
  quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' ';
  color: #666;
  font-style: italic;
}

q::before {
  content: open-quote;
  font-weight: bold;
}

q::after {
  content: close-quote;
  font-weight: bold;
}

/*
HTML: <p><q>This is a quote</q></p>
```

Display: « This is a quote »
(in italics with bold quote marks)
*/

Practical Examples

```
body {
    font-family: Georgia, serif;
}

q {
    quotes: '""' '""' '""' '""';
    font-style: italic;
    color: #333;
}

/*
HTML: <p>She said, <q>Hello world</q>,
to everyone.</p>

Display: She said, "Hello world", to everyone.
(with proper curly quote marks)
*/
```

```
html {
  lang: fr;
}

q {
  quotes: "«" "»" '‘' '’';
}

q::before {
  content: open-quote;
  margin-right: 4px;
}

q::after {
```

```

content: close-quote;
margin-left: 4px;
}

/*
HTML: <p>Il a dit, <q>Bonjour</q>.</p>

Display: Il a dit, « Bonjour ».
(French guillemets with spaces)
*/

```

6.3 Example 3: Nested Quotes (Dialogue)

```
q {
    quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' ';
}

/*
HTML:
<p><q>She said, <q>I'm fine</q>,
so I was happy</q>, he explained.</p>

Display:
"She said, 'I'm fine', so I was happy",
he explained.

Automatic level switching!
*/
```

6.4 Example 4: Accessible Blockquote Alternative

```
blockquote::before {
    content: open-quote;
    font-size: 48px;
    opacity: 0.3;
    margin-right: 8px;
    float: left;
}

blockquote {
    quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' ';
    font-style: italic;
    border-left: 4px solid #3498db;
    padding-left: 16px;
    margin-left: 0;
}

/*
Creates a stylized blockquote with
large opening quote mark
```

```
*/
```

6.5 Example 5: Emphasis Quotes in Body Text

```
.emphasis {
  quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' ';
  font-weight: bold;
  color: #e74c3c;
}

.emphasis::before {
  content: open-quote;
}

.emphasis::after {
  content: close-quote;
}

/*
HTML: <span class="emphasis">Important</span>
news today.

Display: "Important" news today.
(with auto-quotes and styling)
*/
```

6.6 Example 6: Citation Styling

```
cite {
  quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' ';
  font-style: italic;
  font-size: 0.9em;
  color: #666;
}

cite::before {
  content: open-quote " ";
}

cite::after {
  content: " " close-quote;
}

/*
HTML: <p><cite>From the book title</cite>,
we learned...</p>

Display: « From the book title », we learned...
*/
```



```
.testimonial {
  border-left: 4px solid #27ae60;
  padding-left: 16px;
  margin: 16px 0;
  font-style: italic;
  color: #333;
}

.testimonial q {
  quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' ';
  font-weight: bold;
}

.testimonial q::before,
.testimonial q::after {
  color: #27ae60;
  font-weight: bold;
  font-size: 1.2em;
}

/*
Creates professional testimonial styling
with automatic quote marks
*/
```

6.10 Example 10: Multi-Language Support

```
/* English */
:lang(en) q {
  quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' ';
}

/* French */
:lang(fr) q {
  quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' ';
}

/* German */
:lang(de) q {
  quotes: „" „" „" „";
}

/* Spanish */
:lang(es) q {
  quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' ';
}

/* Japanese */
:lang(ja) q {
  quotes: " " " " " " " ";
}
```

```
/*  
Different quote styles per language!  
Use HTML lang attribute:  
<q lang="fr">Bonjour</q>  
*/
```

Chapter 7

The quotes: none Value

7.1 Disabling Automatic Quotes

```
q {  
  quotes: none;  
}  
  
/*  
Result: <q> element displays without  
automatic quote marks  
*/
```

7.2 When to Use none

- When you want manual quote control
- When providing custom quote content
- Resetting inherited quotes
- Special styling requirements

7.3 Example with quotes: none

```
q {  
  quotes: none;  
  background: yellow;  
  padding: 2px 6px;  
}  
  
q::before {  
  content: ">> ";  
  color: red;  
}  
  
q::after {  
  content: " <<";
```

```
    color: red;
}

/*
HTML: <q>Custom quotes</q>

Display: >> Custom quotes <<
(with custom styling, not standard quotes)
*/
```

Chapter 8

Browser Support

8.1 Compatibility

The quotes property is well-supported in all modern browsers:

- Chrome 12+
- Firefox 1.5+
- Safari 5+
- Edge (all versions)
- Opera 4+
- IE 8+
- iOS Safari 4.2+
- Chrome Mobile 12+
- Android Browser 2.1+

8.2 Universal Support

Unlike some CSS properties, quotes has nearly universal support across all modern and legacy browsers. No vendor prefixes needed.

Chapter 9

Common Mistakes

9.1 Mistake 1: Using Wrong Quotation Marks

Wrong:

```
q {  
  quotes: "" ""; /* Single quotes as double */  
}
```

Correct:

```
q {  
  quotes: '' ''; /* Proper double quotes */  
}
```

9.2 Mistake 2: Forgetting Nesting Levels

Problem:

```
q {  
  quotes: '' '';  
  /* No level 2 for nested quotes */  
}  
  
/*  
HTML: <q>She said, <q>Hello</q></q>  
  
Display: "She said, "Hello"  
(confusing - both same quotes)  
*/
```

Solution:

```
q {  
  quotes: '' '' "" "";  
  /* Level 1 and level 2 defined */  
}  
  
/*  
Display: "She said, 'Hello' "
```

```
(clear nesting with different quotes)
*/
```

9.3 Mistake 3: Using on blockquote

Wrong:

```
blockquote {
  quotes: ' ' ' ';
  /* quotes property doesn't apply here */
}
```

Remember: Use quotes with:

- <q> element (inline quotes)
- open-quote/close-quote in content
- NOT <blockquote> (use manual styling)

9.4 Mistake 4: Incorrect Unicode Characters

Problem:

```
q {
  quotes: "«" "»"; /* Correct */
  /* vs */
  quotes: "<" ">"; /* Wrong - angle brackets */
}
```

Use correct Unicode characters:

- « (U+00AB) - Left guillemet
- » (U+00BB) - Right guillemet
- ” (U+201C) - Left double quote
- ” (U+201D) - Right double quote
- ’ (U+2018) - Left single quote
- ’ (U+2019) - Right single quote

9.5 Mistake 5: Order of Quotes

Wrong:

```
q {
  quotes: "closing" "opening";
  /* Reversed order! */
}
```


Correct:

```
q {  
  quotes: "opening" "closing";  
  /* Proper order */  
}
```

Chapter 10

Unicode Quote Characters

10.1 Common Quote Marks

Character	Unicode	Usage
”	U+0022	ASCII double quote
’	U+0027	ASCII single quote
”	U+201C	Left double quote
”	U+201D	Right double quote
’	U+2018	Left single quote
’	U+2019	Right single quote
«	U+00AB	Left guillemet
»	U+00BB	Right guillemet
‹	U+2039	Left angle quote
›	U+203A	Right angle quote
„	U+201E	Double low quote
”	U+201C	Double high reverse
,	U+201A	Single low quote
’	U+2019	Single high reverse

Chapter 11

Accessibility

11.1 Screen Readers

Automatic quotes via CSS content are:

- Read by screen readers
- Important for accessibility
- Better than relying on font styling
- Semantic and meaningful

11.2 Best Practices

1. Use `<q>` element semantically
2. Set quotes property for language
3. Test with screen readers
4. Ensure quote marks are readable
5. Provide alt text if necessary
6. Match content language to quote style

Chapter 12

Quick Reference

12.1 Quotes Property Syntax

```
/* Single level */
q { quotes: "«" "»"; }

/* Two levels (recommended) */
q { quotes: '‘' '’' '“" '”'; }

/* Three levels */
q { quotes: '‘' '’' '“" '”' "<<" ">>"; }

/* Disable quotes */
q { quotes: none; }
```

12.2 Language-Specific Quotes

Language	Quote Style
English	” ” ’ ’
French	« » ” ”
German	„ ” , ’
Spanish	« » ” ”
Japanese	
Russian	« » „ ”

12.3 Complete CSS Template

```
/* Basic English setup */
q {
  quotes: '‘' '’' '“" '”';
  color: #333;
}

q::before {
  content: open-quote;
```

```
font-weight: 600;
}

q::after {
  content: close-quote;
  font-weight: 600;
}

/* Multi-language support */
:lang(en) q { quotes: ' ' ' ' ' ' ' '; }
:lang(fr) q { quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' '; }
:lang(de) q { quotes: " " " " ' ' ' '; }
:lang(es) q { quotes: "«" "»" ' ' ' '; }
```

12.4 Decision Guide

1. Do you use <q> elements?
 - NO → Skip quotes property
 - YES → Continue
2. What language is your content?
 - English → Use curved quotes
 - French → Use guillemets
 - German → Use straight/curved
 - Other → Find language-specific style
3. Will you have nested quotes?
 - NO → Define 1 level
 - YES → Define 2+ levels

12.5 Common Use Cases

- Blog/article text (main use)
- Dialog in fiction/stories
- Testimonials and quotes
- Pull quotes and highlights
- Citation and references
- Technical documentation
- Multi-language websites
- Accessible content

12.6 Pro Tips

1. Use semantic `<q>` element
2. Define quotes for each language
3. Match typography style to content
4. Test with screen readers
5. Use Unicode characters properly
6. Document quote styles in comments
7. Consider printing (some quotes may not print well)
8. Test with nested `<q>` elements

12.7 Related HTML Elements

- `<q>` - Inline quotation (uses quotes property)
- `<blockquote>` - Block quotation (doesn't use quotes)
- `<cite>` - Citation (for references)
- `<mark>` - Highlighted text
- `<em>` - Emphasis